

Aged 125, it's the party that has matured slowly in the casket of dynasty. An epic narrative in the political history of the subcontinent, its evolutionary story is woven into the collective biography of a family. Stretching from struggle to freedom to power, and undergoing many mutations on the way, its episodic journey has been semaphored by the impulses and imagination of a few individuals whose genealogy set them apart from the rest. The Indian National Congress, deservedly called our Grand Old Party, may no longer be the big banyan tree whose sheltering shadow is home to every social or caste group, and it can no longer claim to have an emotional covenant with the country, but it's the party that, as we step into the second decade of the 21st century, once again rhymes with power, though not absolute power as in another era. And once again, it's another Gandhi who has not let power remain static and provided the kinetics of change.

Rahul Gandhi has turned his ancestral privilege into a ticket for renewal in 2009, the year in which the Congress, with Sonia Gandhi as its Empress Dowager and Manmohan Singh as its most dutiful mandarin, retained the mandate. Power calcifies when it is not invested with the ideas of the audacious. Sonia, despite being the paramount leader of the party, is not yet Mrs G in the original sense, and Manmohan, despite being a saleable mascot of sobriety and stability, is not a natural politician. Rahul, the Crown Prince who has made I'm-not-ready-yet his existential badge, used the licence of his bloodline to defy tradition and begin a kind of renaissance within the Congress.

In the age of cohabitation, the sort of political bedfellowship in which the pleasures of power are independent of moral decency, he refused to play along, that too in spite of the truth that his party can't keep Delhi without partners. It was the dream of the vintage Congress that inspired him as he played out the script of the warrior prince in his *karmabhumi*. The Congress's solo act in Uttar Pradesh, the home state of the Nehru-Gandhi mythology, in the last General Election was Rahul's rejoinder to the cosy assumptions of coalition politics. Holy Ghosts must have been watching in approval as he regained a bit of the lost shine in India's most influential state where the

Congress was made redundant by other competing sociologies of empowerment.

It is the power of the surname that gives him that rare functional autonomy in a party where the Leader is always spelt with a Capital L.—and makes him both indispensable and inevitable. Rahul in 2009 used that privilege of the Chosen One to introduce us to what could be called Compassionate Congressism. His so-called Discovery of India tours—the prince in a photogenic poverty backdrop—brought the politics of *aam aadmi* out of the shallowness of the stump speech into the sweltering dust bowls of the shirtless—and to the front pages. It was his education as well, but his self-portrait as the keeper of the party's social conscience provided a necessary counterbalance to the geopolitical and free-market imperatives of the Manmohan Government. Development doesn't sound so banal when he utters the word.

Maybe because it has the resonance of idealism.

For he has given politics a blood rush of youthfulness in a country where more than 70 per cent of the population is of his age (39) or younger, and where biological antiquity is equated with wisdom. So in a nation of leaders vsop (a prime minister at 77 and the man who coveted his job at 82), he has more representational value. And youth in politics, as in any other endeavour today, has to be about change, politics' oldest cliché but a

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word of revolutionary potential ever since a freshman senator in his 40s became the President of America (though the joke now is about "the change we can't believe in"). And a Conservative at 43 is six months away from becoming the next prime minister of Britain. Rahul, still the reluctant heir, seems to prefer the power that comes without the responsibility of being in the highest political office of the country to bring a cultural shift in India's natural party of governance.

He is INDIA TODAY Newsmaker of the Year because he has used the hereditary privileges of a Gandhi to repudiate the dead certainties of politics-as-usual. His father dreamed of an India "in the front ranks of the world". The son may not have come out with a matching vision statement but the Gandhi in waiting has given his party, the oldest political tradition in India, the freedom to dream differently, making him the most influential political catalyst of the year. ■